Ubi primum

Pius IX · 1849-02-02 · English

PICS p.p., IX. "Venerable brethren — health and apostolical bene- diction. When raised at the flrst, certainly by no merits of our own, but by the secret counsel of Divine Providence, to the sublime chair of the Prince of the Apostles, we undertook the government of the whole Church, we feel the greatest consolation, venerable brethren, when we know in what manner, in the ponti- ficate of our predecessor, Gregory the Sixteenth, of venerable memory, an ardent desire had wonderfully revived in the Catholic world, that it should, at length, be decreed by the Apostolic See, by a solemn judgment, that the most holy Itlother of God, the most loving mother of us all, the immaculate Virgin Mary, was coa- ceived without the original stain; which most pious desire, the petitions presented as well to the said pre- decessor of ours as to ourselves continually, most clearly and openly prove and demonstrate ; in which the most distinguiehed prelates, the most illustrious colleges of the Cmons, and the religious establishments, among whom is the renowned, order of preaching Friars, have, with rivalry, solicited that in the sacred liturgy, especially in the preface of the Mass of the conception of the most Blessed Virgin, it should be lawful to openly and pub- licly pronounce and add that word ' Immaculate.' To which petitions it was agreed, with the utmost readiness, by our predecessor and ourselves. It has also come to pass, venerable brethren, that very many of your own order have not ceased to address your letters to our pre- decessor and to us, in which they have sought, with re- peated petitions and redoubled desires, that we should be willing to define, as a doctrine of the Catholic Church, th&t the conception of the Blessed Virgin Mary was altogether immaculate and wholly free from all stain of original sin. Kor, indeed, were there wanting, even in this our age, men excelling in capacity, virtue, piety, doctrine, who, by their learned and laborious writings of this kind, have so illustrated this subject, and most pious opinion, that many persons wonder why this honour has not yet been decreed to the most Holy Virgin by the Church and theApostolic See : which (honour) the com- mon piety of the faithful so much desires should be at- tributed to that Virgin, by the solemn judgment and authority of that same Church and See. Indeed, wishes of this kind have been most pleasing and agreeable to us, who, even from our most tender years, have held nothing preferable, nothing more dear than to worship the most Blessed Virgin Mary with a singular piety and service, and with the most inward affection of our heart, and to perform those things which appear to be able to conduce to the greater glory of the Virgin her- self, and to procure her praise, and to promote her wor- ship. Wherefore, even from the very beginning of our pontificate, we seriously directed our cares and thoughts, even with the greatest alacrity, towards an affair of so great importance, and have not omitted to offer our most humble and fervent prayers to the best and greatest God, that he may be willing to illuminate our mind with the light of his celestial grace, by which we may be able to learn what should be done by us in this affair. We also endeavour to remain in this hope most strongly, that the Blessed Virgin, ' who has raised the highest pitch of merit above all quires of angels, even to the throne of God,' and who has crushed under the foot of her virtue the head of the old serpent, who, 'placed between Christ and his church' and altogether great and full of graces, has always rescued the Christian people from the greatest calamities whatsoever, and from the snares and assaults of all enemies, and has saved them from perishing, commisserating with that most ample affection of her maternal mind, with which she is accustomed, our most sad and mournful vicissi- tudes and most bitter necessities. Labours, and distresses, will be willing, with her most present, and also her most powerful patronage with God, to turn away the scourge of divine anger with which we are afSicted on account of our sins, and to restrain and dissipate the most tur- bulent storms of evils by which, with incredible grief to our mind, the Church is everywhere tossed, and to convert our grief into joy. For you know full well, venerable brethren, that all ground of our confidence is placed in the most holy Virgin, since God ' has placed the fulness of all good in Mary, so that, if there be any hope in us, if any grace, if any salvation, we may know that it flows from her . . . because such is the will of him who wills that we should have all through Mary."

__ "Hence, we have chosen same ecclesiastical men, dis- tinguished for their piety, and well versed in theological study, and some of our venerable brethren, cardinals of the Roman Church, illustrious for their virtue, religion, counsel, prudence, and knowledge of divine things, and we have committed to them that, according to their prudence and learning, they should

take care to exa- mine on every side this most grave subject, and then report to us their opinion with all diligence. But while the matter stands in this position, we have resolved to follow the illustrious footsteps of our predecessors, and to emulate tlicir example.

" Wherefore, we write these letters to you, venerable brethren, in which we by all means excite your distin- guished piety and episcopal care ; and again and again, we enjoin you, that each of you, according to his judg- ment and prudence, will take care that public prayers should be appointed and performed in his own diocess, by which means the most merciful Father of lights may think fit to pour out upon us of the heavenly light of his Divine Spirit, to breathe on us of his inspiration, that in matter of so great importance, we may be able to embrace that counsel which may pertain as well to the greater glory of his holy name, as to the greater praise of the most Blessed Virgin, as well as to the greater good of the Church mihtant. But we earnestly desire, that with the greatest speed with which it can be done, you will signify to us with what devotion your clergy and faithfiti. people are animated towards the conception of the immaculate Virgin, and with what de- sire they are inflamed, that a matter of this kind should be determined by the Holy See ; and especially we de- sire to know what you, yourselves, venerable brethren,

think of this matter, according to your distinguished wisdom, and what you wish. And, since we liave now conceded to the Koman clergy, that they may be able to recite the proper canonical hours of the conception of the most Blessed Virgin, recently composed and pub- lished, in place of that which is contained in the ordi- nary Breviary : therefore, by these letters, we give you power, venerable brethren, that, if it so please you, the whole clergy of your diocess may be able, freely and carefully, to use those canonical hours of the conception of the most holy Virgin, which the Boman clergy now uses, without your being obliged to ask liberty from us, or our Congregation of Sacred Rites.

" We do not doubt, venerable brethren, but that, ac- cording to your singular piety towards the most holy Virgin Mary, you will rejoice to comply with these our desires, with all care and zeal, and that you will hasten to give us the speedy reply which we ask of you. In the meanwhile receive, as a pledge of all heavenly gifts, and especially of our benevolence towards you, the apostolic benediction, which, from the bottom of our heart, we bestow on you, venerable brethren, and on all the clergy and faithful people committed to your care.

"Given at Cajeta, this second day of February, in the year 1849, the third year of our Pontificate."

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